

*Catha edulis* (Celastraceae)Khat,  
Catha

**Description** Tree growing to 49 ft (15 m). Has reddish twigs, oval leathery leaves, and small yellow or white flowers.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Native to the Middle East and the Horn of Africa, khat prefers grassland and arid conditions. It is cultivated in Ethiopia, Somalia, East Africa, and the Arabian peninsula.

**Parts Used** Leaves, twigs.

**Constituents** Khat contains alkaloids similar to those in *Ephedra* species—norpseudoephedrine (up to 1%) and ephedrine, tannins, and a volatile oil. Ephedrine-type alkaloids strongly stimulate the central nervous system, are antiallergenic, and suppress the appetite.

**History & Folklore** Khat is taken in some African and Middle Eastern countries as a stimulant, tonic, and appetite suppressant. Infused, smoked, or chewed, khat produces an effect somewhat similar to that of coca leaves (*Erythroxylum coca*, p. 206). Whether khat is addictive is unclear, but withdrawal can produce lethargy.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Mainly used as a social drug, khat is also chewed fresh or taken in an infusion to treat ailments such as malaria. In Africa, it is taken in old age, stimulating and improving mental function. Khat is used in Germany to counter obesity.

⚠ **Cautions** Khat may cause headaches, raised blood pressure, and general overstimulation if used more than a few weeks at a time. Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

*Caulophyllum thalictroides*

## (Berberidaceae)

## Blue Cohosh

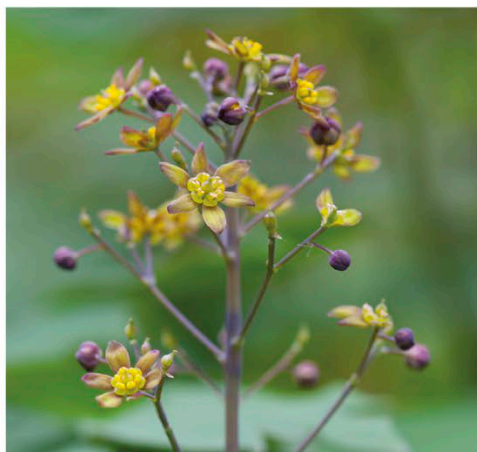
**Description** Upright perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m) with large, 3-lobed leaves, yellow to purple flowers, and striking blue berries.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Blue Cohosh grows wild in much of eastern North America from Manitoba to Alabama, preferring woodland valleys and damp, north-facing slopes. It is mainly wild-harvested but is also cultivated commercially.

**Parts Used** The root and rhizome are harvested in the autumn.

**Constituents** Blue cohosh contains alkaloids, steroidal saponins, and resin.

**History & Folklore** "Cohosh" is an Algonquin name, and blue cohosh was a popular herb with many Native American tribes. Though it was taken by both sexes to treat genitourinary problems, it was primarily considered a women's herb.



*Blue cohosh* is mainly wild-harvested but is also cultivated commercially.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Current medicinal uses of blue cohosh are not that different from the past—the root is still valued as a women's remedy. It is often prescribed as a uterine tonic, bringing relief from uterine and ovarian pain, while regulating to improve menstrual blood flow. The herb also has anti-inflammatory activity and may be used in treatments for arthritic and rheumatic conditions.

⚠ **Cautions** Only take under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding. The plant can cause contact dermatitis.

*Cedrus* spp. (Pinaceae)

## Cedar

**Description** Cedar of Lebanon (*C. libani*) is a majestic flat-topped tree growing to 130 ft (40 m). It has dark green needle-like leaves and oval cones. African cedar (*C. atlantica*) grows to 115 ft (35 m).

**Habitat & Cultivation** Cedar of Lebanon is native to mountain forests of Lebanon, Israel, and southwest Turkey. Atlas cedar is native to the Atlas Mountains of Morocco, growing from 4,600–7,200 ft (1,400–2,200 m) above sea level.

**Parts Used** Leaves, wood, essential oil.

**Constituents** The essential oil of Atlas cedar wood contains mainly alpha-pinene (up to 79%).

**History & Folklore** Cedar of Lebanon is thought to have been used in building Solomon's Temple and the Hanging Gardens of Babylon. The oil has been used for thousands of years in incense, perfumes, and embalming.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Cedar of Lebanon is antiseptic and expectorant, acting to disinfect the respiratory tract. Cedarwood essential oil has been used for thousands of years for perfumes and for embalming. It is most commonly distilled from Atlas cedar and eastern red cedar (*Juniperus virginicus*). The oil is strongly antiseptic, astringent, diuretic, expectorant, and sedative. Diluted and massaged

into the skin, it treats congestion, chest infections, and cystitis. It is used to treat skin wounds and ulcers.

**Caution** Do not take essential oil of cedar internally except under professional supervision.

*Celtis australis* (Ulmaceae)

## European Nettle Tree

**Description** Dome-shaped deciduous tree growing to 80 ft (25 m). Has lance-shaped leaves, green flowers, and small round purple-black fruits.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Native to the Mediterranean region and southwestern Asia, European nettle tree is also planted as a border tree in Italy and France.

**Parts Used** Leaves, fruit.

**Constituents** European nettle tree contains tannins and mucilage.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Due to their astringent properties, both the leaves and the fruit of European nettle tree may be taken as a decoction to reduce heavy menstrual and intermenstrual uterine bleeding. The fruit and leaves may be used to astringe the mucous membranes of the gut in peptic ulcers, diarrhea, and dysentery.

*Centaurea cyanus* (Asteraceae)

## Cornflower

**Description** Annual or biennial plant growing to 3 ft (90 cm). Has a multi-branched stem, a basal rosette of leaves, and sky-blue flowers in summer.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Native to the Near East, cornflower grows wild in all temperate regions, often in cornfields. The flowers are gathered just after they open.

**Parts Used** Flowers, seeds, leaves.

**Constituents** Cornflower contains flavonoids, sesquiterpene lactones (including cnicin), acetylenes, and coumarins. Cnicin is slightly antibiotic.

**History & Folklore** Cornflower's medicinal properties were first mentioned in the 12th-century writings of Hildegard of Bingen. Later, the herbalist Pierandrea Mattioli (1501–1577) recommended it on the basis of the Doctrine of Signatures, which held that a plant's appearance indicated the ailments it would cure. Cornflower's deep blue color symbolized healthy eyes, and for this reason it became a treatment for eye ailments. (In France, the plant is called *casse-lunette*, or "break glasses.")

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Cornflower is still used in French herbal medicine as a remedy for the eyes (the strained infusion is used as an eyewash, and the petals applied as a poultice), but opinion differs as to its efficacy. The petals are also taken as a bitter tonic and stimulant, improving digestion